DADDY DEAREST

THE NIZAM IN **ANEES SALIM'S** NOVEL HAS SO MANY CHILDREN THAT THEIR VOICES TOGETHER CREATE A POLYPHONY

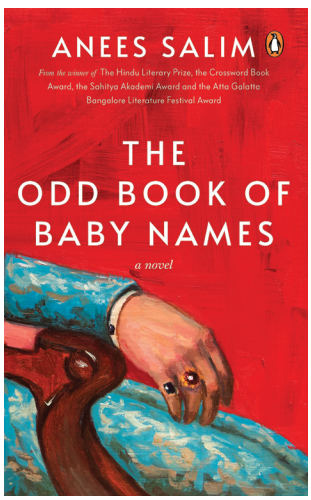
Anees Salim's new novel is set between the day the Nizam did not die and the day on which he died. The era is one in which the Nizam is old, shrunken and powerless, but certainly not forgotten—the premature news of his death closes down shops and melts women into tears, before the city, half-embarrassed at its mistake, starts ticking again. The narrators are his children. Two of them are the acknowledged sons, and they live in the palace. The rest are the scattered progeny of nautch girls and others who have caught his eye or been procured for him at various times. There may be a dozen of them, or 149, or some number in between, but the Nizam has all their names down in a book.

Moazzam, the eldest, is the alcoholic heir to nothing in particular. He soaks in the bathtub, contemplating the sparrows that perch on the edge of the tub, which seem to contemplate him in turn. Azam, his half-brother who lives in the palace, searches for that book in which his father has named all his children. The stammering Hyder also lives in the palace, but as a mere attendant to his comatose and flatulent father, ready to alert his betters when life has ceased to sputter in His Highness. Humera is special enough to be given birthday gifts from the palace till she turns 16. On that birthday she is invited to eat cake with her father and then dismissed for good.

The Nizam's other progeny speak from their various lowly positions. The tailor proud to craft the fez that sits on his royal father's head. The layabout who scrounges for an old fez to connect himself with the father who has forgotten him. The ghost of the half-brother he played with as a child. The sap who is a desperate voice on the phone, trying to claim the diamond the Nizam once promised him. And the chaiwallah's menial, who works for food and sleeps on a verandah, but knows that his mother was once sold for the night to the Nizam when the royal train halted in the middle of nowhere.

The city of Salim's creation is small, defined as in a fairy tale with a palace, a mosque, narrow lanes, a garden and a lake. The Nizam's children fill this sketchy landscape. In scenes that are painted more in water colours than in oils, their paths naturally cross and re-cross, with consequences that don't quite amount to tragedy. The novel exudes, rather, a wistful sorrow, the sorrow of souls in search of acknowledgement and belonging. ■

–Latha Anantharaman

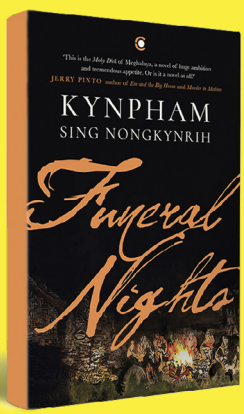


THE ODD BOOK OF BABY NAMES
by Anees Salim
PENGUIN HAMISH HAMILTON
₹599; 288 pages

MY BEST OF 2021



JERRY PINTO
Author; translator



FUNERAL NIGHTS
by Kynpham Sing Nongkynrih
CONTEXT
₹899, 1,024 pages

The Moby-Dick of Meghalaya, this is a challenging read but ultimately rewarding. The term 'ambition' has become a cliché but this one genuinely has it, in spades. A group of friends set out for a funeral ritual and tell each other Canterburyesque tales along the way.